

way? If so, how much are you willing to pay for it? If not, then why bother?

7. Location, location, location

It stands to reason that the hotels located in the middle of it all will charge a pretty penny for the convenience. By staying somewhere a little further out, you may get a better sense of the city and its people by taking public transportation, and/or by walking more (which never hurts when you're eating all those rich vacation meals).

8. Choose your amenities

Although a pool, spa, exercise room, wireless Internet, rooftop patio, and bathrobes may sound luxurious, will you use them? As much as I love seeing a bathrobe in my suite, I almost never use it. Why would I lollygag about in my room wearing a robe when I can go out and explore the place I came to visit? And as much as I'd like to sit in the sauna, I probably won't. Look for the more basic accommodations; you'll save lots of money.

RENTING A CAR

9. If you are visiting a city, don't bother renting a car

Lots of city dwellers don't have cars, so try living like they do. Take public transportation, and walk lots.

10. If you must, go with a compact option

With the cost of fuel skyrocketing, the luxury sedans we like to get upgraded to will end up costing dearly. Do your pocketbook and the environment a favor: Keep it small, and don't drive it unless you need to.



TOURS

Sure, you need to be frugal, but don't sacrifice the things you really want to see for the expense of seeing them. If you want to see the Great Barrier Reef but balk at the price of the scuba-diving trip, then consider a snorkeling trip instead. Or, book the boat trip from a further-out and lesser-known port. If you come and go without seeing it because of the cost, you'll be kicking yourself all the way home.

11. Make a group list

Each person in the family should choose one thing they really want to do on the vacation. Put it all on a list, and discuss the options and costs. This is a great way for the whole family to participate in the trip-planning process, and for children to become aware of the financial balance and